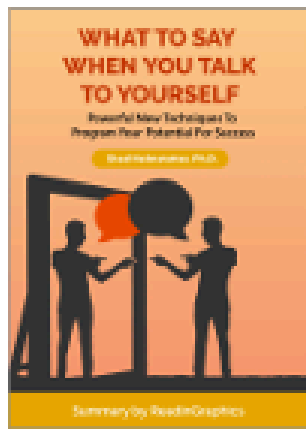




WHAT TO SAY WHEN YOU TALK TO YOURSELF

Powerful New Techniques To
Program Your Potential For Success

SHAD HELMSTETTER, PH.D.



The Big “So What”

We talk to ourselves all the time. Yet, we don't realize that much of what we tell ourselves is negative or counter-productive. **This book presents insights from 20 years of behavioral research, with specific steps and phrases that you can use to reprogram your brain, achieve your goals, live your desired life and reach your full potential.**



Introduction



Today, we're surrounded by all sorts of success tips and strategies to help us overcome challenges and move forward in life. These include: positive thinking, goal setting, time management, self-belief, self-responsibility, meditation, eating right, and so on.

- Helmstetter spent 20 years researching success from different angles—from psychology to neuroscience, business, philosophy, and religion. He tried out many of the recommended solutions, and also spoke with others who've tried them. Most of these strategies work to some extent, but the effects tend to be temporary because they fail to address how our brain works.
- **The brain controls everything we think and do. To make a permanent change, we need to reprogram the subconscious mind, which is the brain's command center.** In this book, Helmstetter explains how you can do so using self-talk. It's like the glue that binds together all the other success factors.



The book was originally written in 23 short chapters. In this summary, we've organized the ideas into 2 parts:

KEY QUOTES

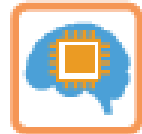
“If there are so many good solutions, why aren't they creating permanent changes in our lives?”

“The brain runs the ship. If you want to make a permanent change of any kind...you've got to do it the way the brain works.”

- How mental programming works; and
- How to reprogram your brain with self-talk.



Part 1: How Mental Programming Works



How does the brain work?



The brain is made up of billions of neurons that communicate via neurotransmitters. Electrochemical signals are passed between the neurons, triggering chemical releases to our central nervous system and body, which then control everything we do.

- The brain keeps us alive by monitoring our needs and managing all our bodily systems (e.g. breathing, digestion) without our conscious awareness.
- It also responds to mental commands in the form of thoughts. Every conscious or unconscious thought is translated to electrical impulses that affect some parts of our brain.



Think of your brain like a computer that executes whatever instructions it receives.

- We input data or instructions into a computer via a keyboard or touch screen. The data/program is stored in the hard drive, and the programming results are displayed on the computer screen.
- Similarly, the brain receives inputs via our 5 senses, i.e. what we see, hear, taste, touch, or smell. The programming is stored in the subconscious mind, and the results are displayed through our actions or appearance.



The subconscious mind is like the brain's command center. It stores our programming, and has countless electrochemical "switches" that control everything from our memory to our health, attitude, fears, logic, creativity, hopes and dreams.

- Your subconscious mind doesn't differentiate between thought and reality. It believes what it hears repeatedly. This applies to information about wealth, relationships, health,

KEY QUOTES

"You can reprogram...All you have to do is learn how to talk to yourself."

"What we put into our brains is what we will get back out."

"You will become what you think about most; your success or failure in anything, large or small, will depend on your programming—what you accept from others, and what you say when you talk to yourself."

career, etc. So, you literally become what you think about the most.



Wrong or counter-productive inputs can lead to negative programming that works against you without your realization.

- Behavioral research found that 77% of our thoughts are negative. Medical research found that 75% of diseases are self-induced.
- When we try to adopt a new success strategy, it often works for a while before we find ourselves falling back to old habits governed by our old programming. The only way to change permanently is to change our underlying program.



Where did your programming come from?



From the moment we're born, we receive programming inputs from others. We're told what we can or cannot do, what we're good or bad at, how we should behave, and even what we should believe.

- As children, we were full of wonder and imagination, constantly dreaming up possibilities of what we *could* do. As we grew up, we started to learn what we *couldn't* do, and what we *should* or *must* do. We constantly receive (i) direct rules or instructions on what to do (or not to do), (ii) persuasive or marketing messages, and (iii) cues from role models and other social influences.
- Our current mental programming is the sum of what others have told us repeatedly over the years. We believe what we hear the most, regardless of whether it's true.



We also talk to ourselves constantly through spoken words, silent thoughts, feelings, impressions, or physical responses. Much of this occurs unconsciously without our awareness.

- Our brain "files" new data based on what we already know, i.e. every new thought or mental image is tied to an existing thought or image. For example, you may identify a new scent by thinking "this smells like vanilla", or you may dismiss something as "untrue" if it clashes with an existing belief.

KEY QUOTES

"Everything around us nudges, demands, or persuades...We are ships with countless captains, all seeking to direct us on their own courses, for their own purposes."

"The more files we have in our mental filing cabinets... the more we will attract and accept other thoughts and ideas which support and prove what is already stored in our files."

As a result, we tend to reinforce what we already know or believe. The longer you believe in something, the harder it is to change it.

- Persistent and negative self-talk can create a self-made wall that blocks us from our goals. You reinforce that wall each time you tell yourself something counter-productive, e.g. "I'm bad with names", "This is useless", "I'm so clumsy!", or "I'll never get it right." If you keep telling yourself you can't be rich or you can't lose weight, your subconscious mind will make it a reality because that's what you're programming it to do.



In addition, we pass our programming on to others. We often do this unintentionally when we say things like: "You're so self-centered," "You're just like your mum!" or "You'll never amount to anything!"



You can reprogram your brain by changing (i) what programming you accept from others, and (ii) how you talk to yourself. The key is to keep only the helpful programming and replace the rest.



The 5-Step Self-Management Sequence

Your success or failure is *always* the outcome of something you did or didn't do. It's never due to luck alone. **There are 5 elements that determine your results: your behaviors, feelings, attitudes, beliefs and programming.**



Your behaviors directly affect your outcomes. These include what you do or don't do, what you say and how you say it. You probably won't do well for your exams if you skip classes and don't study. You're unlikely to have a happy home life if you constantly ignore or quarrel with your family members.



Our behaviors are in turn driven by our feelings. You'll respond more positively and enthusiastically to someone/something you

KEY QUOTES

"Whatever 'thoughts' you have programmed into yourself, or have allowed others to program into you, are affecting, directing, or controlling everything about you."

"Life is not a matter of luck or fortune...Most of what seems to happen to you happens because of you—something you created, directed, influenced, or allowed to happen."

like, compared to someone/something you dislike. You behave differently when you're happy and optimistic, compared to when you're unhappy or anxious.



Your feelings are in turn influenced by your attitudes or perspectives about life. All else being equal, someone with a great attitude is more likely to succeed than someone with a poor attitude.



Our attitudes are shaped by our beliefs about ourselves, other people, or the world at large. It doesn't matter if a belief is true; what matters is that you believe it's true. Such beliefs tend to become self-fulfilling prophecies. For example, if you believe that people are bad by nature, you'll be more cautious around others. If you believe that you lack creativity, you're less likely to embark on artistic or innovative projects.



Ultimately, our beliefs come from our programming, or how we have been conditioned since young. To change at the core, you need to change your programming.



Self-Talk vs Other Self-Help Concepts



Positive thinking is a powerful self-help concept. However, it doesn't remove your old programming. This is like trying to renovate a house full of old furniture—you must clear out the old furniture to make space for new ones. In short, you must concurrently delete the old/negative self-talk and replace it with new/positive self-talk. Otherwise, your old programming will interfere with your attempt to be positive, and you end up feeling even more frustrated and disillusioned.



Most motivational strategies or techniques don't deliver lasting results because they rely on external motivation or motivators.

- External motivation doesn't last because your motivation fizzles out once the motivator is removed. For example:
 - (i) You may feel a surge of hope and inspiration after reading a motivating book, listening to a stirring speech, or attending a motivational program. However, after a few setbacks, you find yourself falling back to old ways of thinking, and may even feel more disappointed or disillusioned.

KEY QUOTES

"[Self-talk] changes the programming, which creates the belief, which develops the attitude, which creates the feelings, which control the behavior."

"What we believe about anything will determine our attitudes about it, create our feelings, direct our actions, and in each instance, help us to do well or poorly, succeed or fail."

"Most motivation simply doesn't stick. It doesn't stay with you."

"External motivation is the kind that may wake you up, but it will not keep you awake for long."

(ii) You may also feel pressured or obliged to do something due to contractual obligations, fear of punishment, or disapproval. Yet, once the external demands disappear, so will your motivation.

- Instead of relying on external sources of motivation, use self-talk to create internal motivation that lasts. It's like having an internal coach or motivator who will never leave you.

 It's possible to influence your subconscious mind using subliminal solutions, such as *hypnosis* (which puts you in a trance-like state so you become more receptive to suggestions), or *subliminal learning* (e.g. music or images embedded with hidden messages). However, you are still allowing someone else to program your mind.

- Self-talk adopts a different approach. It requires you to make a conscious decision about who you wish to be, then take personal responsibility for your own mental programming.

 No matter how good an idea is, it won't work if you don't apply it. Most people want to improve their relationships/career, and have more time, money, or freedom. Yet, they get so caught up with the demands of daily life that they can't find the time/energy to take concrete action. Self-talk is simple enough that anyone can use it—if they choose to do so.



Part 2: Reprogramming Your Mind with Self-Talk



The 5 Levels of Self-Talk

There are 5 progressive levels of self-talk. **Your goal is to stop unhelpful self-talk (Levels 1 and 2), and start adopting helpful self-talk (Levels 3 and 4). With time, Level 5 will naturally kick in.**

- Level 1: Negative acceptance involves saying negative things about yourself and believing them. It's characterized by words like "I can't..." or "If only I could..." It could range from small



KEY QUOTES

"Vote your own vote, think for yourself, and always be aware of what you are programming into your own subconscious mind."

"Personal responsibility is the bedrock of all individual action."

"For any self-improvement concept to be successful, it has to be simple. It has to be easy to use. And when put into practice, it has to work!"

reservations to deep fears, e.g. "I can't seem to get this right" or "If only I could be more lovable." This is the least helpful way to talk to yourself, since it damages your self-image and confidence.

- Level 2: Admitting the need for change. Such self-talk is characterized by words like "I need to...", "I ought to...", or "I should..." Examples include: "I need to lose weight" or "I really ought to be more punctual". The statements may seem helpful, but they're actually counterproductive because they point out a gap/problem without a concrete solution. This makes you feel more guilty and frustrated.
- Level 3: Deciding to change. This is the first helpful level of self-talk because it represents a firm decision to do something. It's characterized by words like "I never..." or "I no longer..." Examples include: "I never break a promise" or "I no longer eat more than I should". The sentences are stated in the present tense as if the change has already occurred. This instructs your subconscious mind to take action *immediately*.
- Level 4: Being a better me. This is about presenting yourself in a positive new light. It's characterized by words like "I am..." or "I have". Examples include: "I am in control of my actions", "I have a great memory", or "I am a winner!" Such statements inspire us to become the person we wish to be, filling us with hope and excitement.
- Level 5: Universal affirmation. At this level, you're spiritually aligned with the world at large. You use words that describe what is, e.g. "Life is beautiful and full of joy and peace." Your self-talk is elevated to a higher level, reflecting a wider perspective and a higher consciousness.



The 5 Self-Talk Techniques

Self-talk may be thought, spoken, written/read, or recorded/listened to. **Use some or all of these 5 techniques to shift from negative to positive self-talk.**



Silent self-talk refers to your internal dialogues, including all your conscious/unconscious thoughts about yourself and the things around you. The idea is to "catch" any unhelpful thoughts and reframe them *immediately*.

KEY QUOTES

"By replacing your earlier negative or neutral self-talk with new commands, you are activating healthy, productive chemical and electrical control centers in your brain which will automatically work for you instead of against you."

 When you say something about yourself to others, it calls up images and feelings that add to your mental programming. For example, each time you tell a friend that you hate your job, or that you can't stand your boss, you're reinforcing those attitudes and sentiments. Pay attention to *everything* you say—if you don't want your brain to receive it as an instruction, then replace the words immediately.

 Hold conversations with yourself: talk to yourself aloud for several minutes in private, e.g. when you're in the shower or alone in the car. This is one of the most effective forms of self-talk, since you're engaging multiple senses, and forcing yourself to translate thoughts into words. You can use this to:

- Give yourself a boost. For example, say "Hey, you look great today!", then reply with "Yes, it has been an amazing day because...";
- Give yourself advice; or
- Ask yourself questions. This helps you to voice out answers that you may already know subconsciously.

 Written self-talk: Carefully craft the wordings or instructions for your subconscious mind, then read the self-talk daily.

- You can write the self-talk on index cards, with 1 statement per card. Over time, you'll have a self-talk for every situation or goal.
- To come up with the most effective wording, you will need some effort and discipline. So, this method works best for people who enjoy word-smithing. The process also creates the awareness and focus to accelerate your mental shift.

 Recorded self-talk: You can also record your self-talk, then listen to the audios while you do your daily chores or activities. Remember: if you repeat a message enough times, your brain will eventually accept it as the truth.



How to Apply Self-Talk

 Effective self-talk involves more than just 1-2 statements. **You need to develop a set of specific suggestions to tackle different**

KEY QUOTES

"Listen to everything you say when you talk to anyone at anytime."

"Your subconscious mind will be listening, whether you are or not."

"Self-Talk is not one simple phrase or two: Self-Talk is a specific set of concisely worded directions."

aspects of a goal or challenge. The more specific and complete the picture, the clearer the instructions to your brain.

- Be very specific: look at the problem carefully, and create a self-talk statement to address each obstacle. Be as precise as possible, since your brain will follow the exact instruction.
- Most goals or problems can be holistically addressed with a dozen good self-talk suggestions that jointly cover the symptoms, causes, your mental space and the person you must become.
- With the exception of situational self-talk (elaborated below), all positive self-talk is stated in the present tense, as if it has already occurred. For example, don't say "I'm going to quit smoking," since it tells your brain that you're still smoking right now. Just say, "I don't smoke!"



Self-talk for changing habits. All of us have unhelpful habits that we wish to change or replace.

- Use self-talk to tell your subconscious mind (i) to stop doing something (e.g. stop overspending), and (ii) to start doing something else (e.g. only spend what you planned to). Reject the old habit, and replace it with a new mental image of yourself behaving in the new way.
- Develop a set of self-talk suggestions to address all aspects of the habit. To quit smoking, you can describe how you're enjoying your new state of health, how fit/good you feel, how proud you are of yourself, how you stay in control of your mind and body, and how you respond to cigarettes. Here are 2 self-talk examples:
 - (i) "I really enjoy breathing clean, fresh air, being healthy, and being in complete control of my body and my mind."
 - (ii) "When I see a cigarette, or even think of one, I automatically hear the words, "I do not smoke!"



Self-talk for changing attitudes. Our attitudes act as filters to affect how we see ourselves and the world. They define who we are and impact everything we do. The best way to change your attitudes is to change how you see yourself.

- For example, your attitude toward self-responsibility decides whether you take charge of your life or make excuses for

KEY QUOTES

"Because the subconscious mind does not know what is true and what is not, in time it will accept what you are telling it and act on it."

"To change the habit, change the words."

"We are our attitudes and our attitudes are us."

for yourself. To take full responsibility, develop a set of self-talk suggestions to describe how trustworthy you are, how you never make excuses, and how you take responsibility for your past, present and future. Here are 2 self-talk examples:

- (i) "Each day I acknowledge and accept the responsibility for my actions, my emotions, my thoughts, and my attitude."
- (ii) "I always meet all of the obligations which I accept. And I accept no obligations which I will not meet."



Self-talk for solving problems and achieving goals. You can set goals for virtually anything, from how you wish to live each day, to what you wish to achieve in the short-term, mid-term or long-term. Goals and challenges are basically 2 sides of the same coin. When you overcome a challenge, you also move closer to your goal.

- Use self-talk to improve your approach to problems, e.g.
 - (i) "I am good at breaking large obstacles down into smaller pieces that are easier to handle. And I never make any problem seem bigger than it actually is."
 - (ii) "I do not fear problems, I solve them. I do not avoid problems, I conquer them!"
- You can also use self-talk to target specific problems. Be simple, direct, and craft a self-talk for each aspect of the goal/problem. For example, if your goal is to become more organized, you could use statements like:
 - (i) "I know what to do and when to do it, and I do everything I need to do, when I need to do it."
 - (ii) "I program my mind to make the maximum use of my time. I am in control of my time and how to use it."



Motivational self-talk. The best way to motivate anyone is to influence their emotions.

- Use self-talk to uplift yourself emotionally, boost your confidence, self-belief, and sense of purpose. Examples include:
 - (i) "Today is one of those days when nothing can stand in my way. When I need extra determination, I've got it! When

KEY QUOTES

"The attitudes you have about yourself determine the attitudes you will have about everything else around you."

"Some of the most important goals of all...are the goals of everyday living."

"Name the adversary, state the problem, and you can find the self-talk that created it."

"If you would like to be in control of the forces in your life which influence and affect everything you do, then you most certainly would like to be in control of your own motivation."

(ii) I need more energy and drive, I've got it! No matter what the task is, I have the power to get it done and the patience to see it through."

(iii) "I have a lot of energy and I feel alive!"



Our physiology can be changed in an instant, e.g. you may be dozing off but a loud crash gets you jumping up in full alertness. Use situational self-talk to instantly shift your mental, emotional, or physiological state.

- Change your words to change how you see the situation. All it takes is just a moment. For example, you're receiving a call from someone you dread talking to. Instead of avoiding the call, tell yourself "I love solving problems. I'll take this call and address the issues head-on." Unlike the other types of self-talk, situational self-talk doesn't require a script. There's also no need to use the present tense since you're preparing for an upcoming activity.
- A single event can create a chain reaction to form a positive or negative cycle. Positive self-talk puts you in a better frame of mind, so you can respond in a way that can (i) save yourself hours or days of pain and grief, and (ii) build your confidence and self-esteem.
- When you encounter events beyond your control (e.g. bad weather or slow traffic), there's no point complaining or losing your temper. Use self-talk to help yourself accept or even enjoy the situation. For example: "Slow traffic is not a problem to me. I now enjoy the time to organize my thoughts and think about things that are beneficial to me. I will get there when I get there."



Applying Self-Talk to All Aspects of Life



Self-talk is a self-reinforcing habit. The earlier you start using it, the faster you'll form new, positive ways of talking to yourself.

- You may feel some initial resistance, e.g. an inner voice telling you that it won't work. Just remind yourself that it takes time to change old habits, and consciously choose not to listen to your old programming.

KEY QUOTES

"[Situational Self-Talk] adjusts situations by adjusting how we look at them."

"The more productively we think, the more positively we affect ourselves emotionally and physically."

"If you have made the decision to be in control of yourself, you will talk to yourself in the right way—immediately, directly, realistically, and positively."

- Energize your self-talk by reading them aloud, ideally in front of a mirror. The process may feel awkward at first, but it will feel more natural with practice.
- As you repeat the messages over and over, you'll start to feel better mentally, emotionally, and physically. Once you improve how you see yourself, it will be easier for you to address specific goals or challenges. Eventually you'll internalize the words to make them a part of your life and who you are.



Anyone can benefit from self-talk since our brains work the same way. You can also apply self-talk to any area or challenge in life.

- If you're in management, you can use self-talk to positively shape your own perspectives, attitudes, feelings and actions, and teach your team members to do the same.
- To improve your financial health, use 3 weeks of self-talk to see yourself as someone capable and worthy of financial success. Then, develop goals and plans to make it a reality.
- When parents use positive self-talk, their children often pick it up naturally as part of their early programming. Developing positive self-beliefs in children is the best way to help them to grow up to do the right things.
- Use self-talk to overcome any problem or obstacle. Set clear, meaningful goals and write them down, then use daily self-talk to make it easier to achieve them.
- To improve your skills or studies, use self-talk to improve your ability to listen, concentrate, persevere, build good learning habits, and sharpen your memory.
- If you're feeling lonely or depressed, use positive self-talk to change how you see yourself and the situation.



To get started, here are several steps you can take.

- In the next 48 hours, listen carefully to the self-talk around you.
 - (i) Listen to *your own self-talk*. Notice how you react to risks, problems and opportunities, the positive and negative things you say/think about yourself, and the type of internal responses they generate.

KEY QUOTES

"When you determine who you really are inside, and what you are really capable of accomplishing, it is much easier to see what to do next. Start with your programming; the rest will follow."

"If you'd like your child to do the right things, start at the beginning. Start with his or her Self-Talk."

"Any well-set goal deserves the benefit of well-said words."

"Add Self-Talk to your curriculum. You'll get more from school and more from yourself."

KEY QUOTES

- (ii) Listen to *others' self-talk*. Notice what they say about themselves, about people/things around them, and how it reflects their beliefs and external motivations.
- For 7 days, pay attention to media-talk, i.e. the messages from TV, radio, news media, and what people say about such media-talk. Notice the external influences shaping what you think you should do.
- Once you're aware of the self-talk from yourself and others, you can decide what to accept and what to replace.
- You can start by converting your 10 "most-used" negative self-talk into positive self-talk. For example:
 - (i) "I really must exercise more" can be reframed into "I enjoy exercising and look forward to my daily exercise".
 - (ii) "What a terrible day it has been!" can be reshaped into "Today was alright. I feel good about myself and it will be even better tomorrow!"
- Use this checklist to ensure you've worded your self-talk properly.
 - (i) It is stated in the *present tense* (except for situational self-talk).
 - (ii) It is *specific*, with details to address all aspects of the goal or problem.
 - (iii) It gets the job done without undesired side effects, e.g. "losing weight at all costs" could mean hurting your health.
 - (iv) It is *simple*, easy to use and remember.
 - (v) It is *practical*. Start with what you can achieve, then gradually stretch your limits. Don't aim for miracles right away.
 - (vi) It is *direct, personal and honest*, to address where you are now and who you wish to become.
 - (vii) It demands the *best of you*.

"You are everything that is, your thoughts, your life, your dreams come true. You are everything you choose to be. You are as unlimited as the endless universe."

"Vague directions lead to vague results. The more specific you are, the more specific the directions you will be giving yourself."